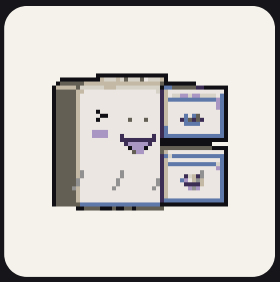
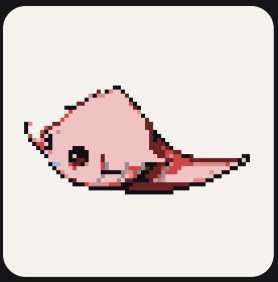
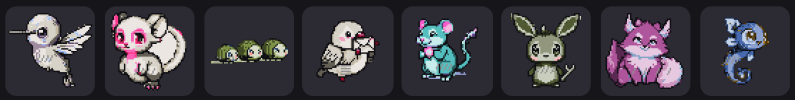
CONTEXT / CONTENT

DAEMONS

The Fourth Review -- the game, the companion and the mind, read as one

REVIEW **4, REVISED** · 14 NOVEMBER 2026
RELEASE **v11.361.1** · DESIGN BIBLE **v11.362**
GAME **8184c63** · COMPANION **49f2da0** · PLAYGROUND **6e8ca37** · DESIGN **b924932d**
FIRST PRINTED 3 NOVEMBER 2026 AT v11.338



An honest external review: strengths, growth, story continuity, the side stories, the arc into the islands, the build, the companion and its local AI. Every word quoted from the game is a DRAFT.
A fan project for the Game Boy Advance. No ROM is in it, or anywhere in DAEMONS.

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About this review

The Fourth Review reads DAEMONS as **one product**: a game you play, a daemon you can bring out of the game onto your phone or a small device, and a mind for it that runs on hardware you own. The three earlier reviews read the design bible; this one reads the bible, the books, the game's source, the companion's source and the playground, and measures each against the others.

What it was read against

Review	**4, revised** -- *The Fourth Review*, first printed 3 November 2026 at v11.338, **revised 14 November 2026 for v11.361**
Design bible	**v11.362** (`docs/vision.md` , 9,500 lines) -- DAEMONS repo at `b924932d` . *First printing: v11.338 at* `1f9f03cb`
Newest release	**v11.361.1** (14 November 2026, the GATEKEEPER), built against bible v11.361. *First printing: v11.337.4*
The game	CodeMusic/pokefirered-daemons, `context-content` at `8184c63` (release engine `dc780f8c5`)
The companion	CodeMusic/daemons-companion at `49f2da0`
The playground	CodeMusic/daemons-playground at `6e8ca37`
Earlier reviews	First (2026-08-31), Second, *The Third Review* (2026-09-10, bible v11.111), ruled on in bible 8.7

This revision re-checked every one of the 46 findings against v11.361 and marks each FIXED, PARTLY, OPEN or NOT RE-CHECKED (Part 2, and the appendix). The first printing's broad measurements -- the text census, the sprite count, the story's sequence -- were not re-run unless a finding depended on them; where a number is still the v11.338 one, it says so. **When the bible moves past v11.362, this revision starts to age.**

How it was read

Four lenses, each read separately and then put together: **the core story** and its sequence into the islands; **the side stories and the books**; **the game as built**, measured block by block against a fresh copy of the original decompilation; and **the companion and its AI**. **Nothing here comes from playing a ROM** -- no ROM was built for this review. The numbers come from the source; the readings are labelled as readings.

The tags are the Third Review's, with one added:

BREAK a contradiction in the canon, the ROM or a published file · **DRIFT** text the project has since overruled and not swept · **FREE** a win already sitting in vanilla or the project's own rules · **IDEA** outside the box, take or leave · **RISK** not wrong yet, but where it will go wrong.

> **What this review never prints.** The four things the player is meant to work out appear nowhere below; where a finding touches one it says *a private secret* and stops. No real person is named, and the frightening word the name is mistaken for is never written. Where a finding is itself about something private, the detail went to the author directly and the page says only that it exists.

PART 1

The verdict, up front

DAEMONS is **the most thoroughly argued fan game this reviewer has read, and the most finished at the level of names and pictures** -- and it is now at the point where its biggest risk is no longer design, but **breadth over finish**. The thesis holds. The main story is built. The islands carry an Act 2. What has not happened is the thing the project's own scope rule exists to force: **someone playing it from a new game to the last scene, and the record of it being read.**

THESIS

Holds, and is in the ROM

LOGIC ½ CONTEXT still survives every lens. The chart is the argument, byte-identical across both editions.

BIGGEST CRACK

The third book

The one exception to craft rule 1 has lost both of the reasons it was allowed -- while its reach grew to three books.

BIGGEST RISK

Breadth over finish

New subsystems keep arriving while the font, the region map, the battle music and the villains' barks are still vanilla.

CHEAPEST BIG WIN

Play it through, once

One recorded playthrough of each edition to the end of Act 2 is worth more than the next feature.

BEST IDEA IN THE PRODUCT

The round trip

Raise it in the game, carry it in your life, bring it home changed. Nobody else has this.

BIGGEST PRODUCT GAP

Talk is unfiltered

Since v11.338 a phone alone can talk, to any endpoint the player links. Nothing yet checks what comes back.

The scorecard

A reading, not a measurement: how far each part is from what its own design asks of it. *Revised for v11.361: only Local AI moved enough to re-score.*

Part	Where it stands
The thesis and the chart	Argued, built, consistent across editions
Names, sprites, Index	99.8% of sprites redrawn; no brand word left

Part	Where it stands
The main story, Act 1	Key scenes rewritten; the villains' barks mostly vanilla
Act 2, the islands	The beats are in; 57% of island text is vanilla by policy
Side stories and books	The early ones load-bearing; the late ones crowding
Story continuity	Rulings land faster than the sweeps behind them
Sound	30 of 110 tracks ours; every battle theme vanilla
The companion	The loop is real and careful; onboarding is long
Local AI	Any endpoint, from the hub or the phone, and on-device; unfiltered, untried by hand
Verification	Superb static checks; no end-to-end play on record

The numbers

99.8%
of 1,476 sprites redrawn, plus 115 new

0
vanilla brand words in 14,194 lines of player text

398
of 412 daemon names ours

3,472
map text blocks: 40% still vanilla, 60% touched

186
releases in 38 days, each with four patches

20,311
lines of new engine C in 33 files

30 / 110
songs ours

494 / 520
tickets closed

0
recorded playthroughs from new game to the end

PART 2

What moved, v11.338 to v11.361

Twelve days, **24 bible versions** (v11.339 to v11.362), **20 release groups** and **386 design commits** after the first printing. Every finding was re-checked against the source at v11.361.1. The short version:

MOST IMPROVED

The companion's mind

A phone alone now talks: to Apple's on-device model, the hub, or any OpenAI-compatible endpoint the player links -- one mind across all three.

MOST IMPROVED, THE GAME

The first screens

Our own font; every place card ours; every General tile ours; every landmark ours but USER TOWER; the SAFARI is THE WALLED GARDEN.

UNMOVED

The finishing list

No playthrough on record; the private sweep, the chart reprint and the TODO tidy all still open.

GREW

The third book

THE UNITY BOOK is built, with an aurora, a fox, a duet and a tablet. Its exception was not narrowed.

What was added in those twelve days

The scope-discipline finding is not a criticism of any one of these; each is well made and most were chosen by the user line by line. It is the list, read together, against the one under *Unmoved*.

Added	Where	Kind
THE UNITY BOOK built -- covers, the torn lines mended, the lens, HALFTONE's tones, the aurora, TULIKKO's sparks, the DUET	4.40	the third book
THE BLANK TABLET by BLANCHE's path, read one face per half	4.39	the third book
THE ORIGIN OF A DAEMON, MUSAI's book; the MUSAI branch's 24 seasonal forms	9.34, 9.35	new book, new art
A day's symbol for each weekday	9.21	calendar
IN ITS OWN WORDS -- each daemon's first-person telling, in the companion only	4.2	companion
THE WALLED GARDEN (the SAFARI ZONE, 76 of 85 lines rewritten) and **the GATEKEEPER**	3.11	**finishing**
Our font; every place card; every General tile; six landmark pairs; THE BLACKOUT	9.29	**finishing**

Added	Where	Kind
The physical/special split, steps 1 and 2 released	2.12	**finishing**
Corpus's last warehouse admins as 8.2a's remnants (T-505)	4.37	**finishing**
Any thinker on the hub and the phone; **THE MIND** across phone, hub and endpoint	C-280, C-307	**the endpoint plan**

Five of ten are finishing work, against roughly one in three in the fortnight before the first printing. That is the right direction, and it should be said plainly.

Every finding, re-checked

FIXED done at v11.361 · PARTLY moved but not closed · OPEN unchanged · NOT RE-CHECKED a reading, or a measurement not re-run.

Finding	Now	Evidence at v11.361
A phone-only player has no AI at all	FIXED	`app/platform/endpoint.ts` and `mesh.ts`: an endpoint from the phone, the on-device model, THE MIND (C-280, C-307). *Not yet tried by hand*
Four designs of the third book, and no build	FIXED	THE UNITY BOOK is in 21 engine files, released from v11.348.2
The first-screen vanilla	PARTLY	Font, place cards, General tiles, landmarks done; **region map (T-449) and every battle theme still vanilla**
Say the unrenamed nouns out loud	PARTLY	SAFARI 34 → 2 (THE WALLED GARDEN); S.S. ANNE 13, GAME CORNER 13, BIKE 14 unchanged
The books disagree about the books	PARTLY	THE SUBTLE LAYER's count fixed (51, v11.357); the GUIDE's three counts still differ
Four lexicon rows	PARTLY	DAEMON LEAGUE 35 → 20 beside REVIEW BOARD 24 -- still two names; CERT still in the lexicon
Bring your own mind: the endpoint plan	PARTLY	Registry, keys and the *at home* ring built; probe, tiers, Ollama's context and the output pipeline not
Nobody has played it from a new game to the end, on record	OPEN	T-50 still open, still the oldest; no route spans BLANCHE to the end

Finding	Now	Evidence at v11.361
What a daemon says is never filtered	OPEN	`safeLine()` still runs only on meetings and the household talk -- **and now any endpoint can answer**
A tracked file tags a private sequence · the bible sentence passed on privately	OPEN	Both still in the public tree
The published type chart is garbled	OPEN	Still 237 broken characters; still no charset
"PROF. CRYSTAL", twice	OPEN	Both strings still in the lab's text
"Never in a room"	OPEN	Still in 8.2a and the warehouse script's comment
The witching hour needs a real clock	OPEN	`DaemonsIsWitchingHour` unchanged
The Hermetic text settles 4.33's question	OPEN	SUBSTRATE unchanged, unattributed
The one exception has lost its warrants	OPEN	Not narrowed; THE UNITY BOOK built around it
HALFTONE's colour returns	OPEN	Deepened, not reversed (v11.340); 3.7 still says it stays grey
Eight tickets filed under Closed	OPEN	**Now ten or more**: T-521, T-522, T-523 joined them
Phone backups never pruned; writes not atomic	OPEN	`app/platform/local.ts` : same write, same backup, no prune
The store record describes a different app	OPEN	`APPSTORE.md` still answers *no gambling*
CI, for free	OPEN	One workflow builds the site; no tests run, none in the app
Sign the patch list · the emulator's CDN, no cache	OPEN	`patches.json` still read live from `main`
Two voices skip DAY-mons	OPEN	`app/AGENTS.md` still lists both as *not covered yet*
The playground serves built ROMs	OPEN	Unchanged

Finding	Now	Evidence at v11.361
The rival's naming device · 6F's ghost story · the hideout's barks · "I understand now" · "It could not have" · the Verdigris kid · Ty at Quicksilver	OPEN	All unchanged in the ROM and the bible. T-505 rewrote the warehouse's admins' battle lines, but Admin 1's *"I understand now..."* is still spoken after the fight
T-506 unswept · school.md says nothing is built · the stale reservation · CLAUDE.md's v11.296 · `still-vanilla.md` · no text census · understandings "THE MARGINS only"	OPEN	All unchanged
The pacing risks · Ty a stranger · thirteen systems · the near-miss · the facing-page binding · the ferry · ordering the exception · the chart is vanilla's · onboarding · the emulator risk	NOT RE-CHECKED	Readings: nothing in the twelve days answers them. The systems count has grown by at least four

> ***FIXED by v11.361: the phone talks to its own on-device model or to any endpoint the player links, with the hub as one more mind (C-280, C-307). Not yet tried by hand.***

> ***PARTLY by v11.361: THE WALLED GARDEN took SAFARI from 34 to 2. The other three are unchanged.***

> ***OPEN at v11.361, and more urgent: any endpoint can now answer, from the phone too.*** *::: callout* ***The one to do first has not changed: play it through, once, and read the record.*** *And one has become more urgent:* ***the output filter.*** *At v11.338 an unfiltered answer came from a 0.5B model on the user's own board. At v11.361 it can come from any model a player points the phone at. :::*

PART 3

What DAEMONS is, as one product

Three pieces, and one loop through them. Every other part of the project -- the books, the dreams, the casino, the boards -- hangs off that loop. **It is the right thing to build everything around.**



THE ROUND TRIP

raise it in the game → SEND it AWAY → it lives on a device, keeps its day, talks
→ SYNC: it goes home with friendship, growth, dreams and money it earned out here

The journey, as a new player meets it

#	Step	State
1	**Get the game** -- your own FireRed or LeafGreen; the one app patches it on the device and checks every hash, or a BPS patch from a release, or the playground	BUILT the one app in TestFlight
2	**Play** -- an emulator core in the app, controllers and keyboards, the iPad's split screen with the companion beside the game	BUILT
3	**Unlock SEND** -- the companion's first SYNC links the save; only then does the party menu offer SEND	BUILT
4	**SEND a daemon AWAY** -- the game only asks; the companion answers at SYNC, re-signs the save and keeps a backup first	BUILT and tested
5	**It lives somewhere** -- the phone and its widget, about twenty boards, a Tab5, a BOX-3	BUILT phone; PARTIAL several boards not yet run

#	Step	State
6	**It talks** -- hold to talk, speech to text, a model answering as the daemon, text to speech	BUILT *v11.361*: phone, hub or any endpoint; untried by hand
7	**It remembers** -- the self in three lengths is built; night memory and the mind portal are designed	DESIGNED
8	**SYNC home** -- friendship, growth, evolution, casino money and gifts written back; RECEIVED says what arrived	BUILT

The game-side loop is real and unusually careful. The AI half was, at v11.338, **only for a household that already ran a computer or a hub**; by v11.361 a phone alone can give its daemon a voice.

PART 4

Strengths

The things this project does better than almost anything in its genre. Each is checkable.

The argument is in the mechanics, not the mouths

- **The chart is the thesis, and it never says so.** LOGIC beats CONTENT ×2 and is resisted by CONTEXT; nobody in the game explains why. Craft rule 1 -- *no character ever explains the colour-emotion link* -- has held for 338 versions of the bible.
- **The type chart is byte-identical across both editions** (invariant 3); it lives in the engine outside the edition switches. An argument that changed by cartridge would not be one.
- **The starters are three ways a machine learns** -- reward, example, unsupervised -- and their final stages are the paradigms' failures side by side: CANON *files new things as errors*, MANIFOLD *can show you the shape, not a name*.



It is finished where players look first

- **No brand word survives.** Across 14,194 lines of player text: `POKéMON` 0, `ROCKET` 0, `GIOVANNI` 0, `KANTO` 0, `SEVII` 0, every vanilla town name 0. The original staff are kept in the credits, on purpose.
- **99.8% of the sprites are redrawn** (1,473 of 1,476), measured by pixel against the original by a census tool, not by memory -- plus 115 new ones. 398 of 412 daemon names, 363 of 383 moves, 240 item names and 275 item descriptions are new.
- **27 maps vanilla never had**: seven school floors, fourteen groves, THE NEXUS and more.

The writing systems are structural

- **The RESEARCH NOTEBOOK files documents in an authored order**, not the order they are found -- *"the file reads correctly when it is complete and never while it is not."* The

player practises exactly the reading the ending needs, and nobody tells them so. It is the best idea after the chart.

- **CALLOW SCHOOL's exam is the inverse of the villain's rigged test, clause by clause** -- a published pass mark, leave mid-paper, retake forever -- and nothing in the game draws the comparison.
- **The islands' tone rule is checkable on a single line**: the mainland *declares, instructs, assesses*; the islands *ask, or offer a second reading.* Measuring it shrank a 9,500-word rewrite to eighteen blocks.
- **The second joining (4.37) is the best late writing** -- a merger that holds both halves, told only through papers and signs, *never in her mouth*.

The engineering habits are rare

- **"Edit the source, never the artifact"** is enforced: generator checks, a sandboxed write check, a drift guard on fifteen tools that refuses to overwrite later hand work, and a fresh-clone build compared byte for byte.
- `check_reach.py` walks every map from where a player arrives -- it found a man standing in the only doorway who had hidden the ending for fifteen days, when every other check passed.
- **43 engine traps documented by symptom.** *Never grep a build for* `error:` is the kind of memory that saves days.
- **Tickets measure before they build.** T-26 shrank by an order of magnitude because someone counted first.

The legal line is drawn in code

- **No ROM in any repository.** Four BPS patches a release, made against byte-identical builds of retail and checked by patching a real retail ROM. The one app checks the player's dump by hash, downloads the patch, checks it, applies it and checks the result. It holds nothing of Nintendo's and collects nothing for its developer.

The companion respects the save and the small model

- **A backup before every write**, sector checksums re-signed, the last battler always stays home, and an in-game recall if the companion is gone.
- **The AX630's real quirks are measured and engineered around** -- a pooled-prompt bug, a ~350-token window, slot leaks -- with fault counters. Models are discovered from

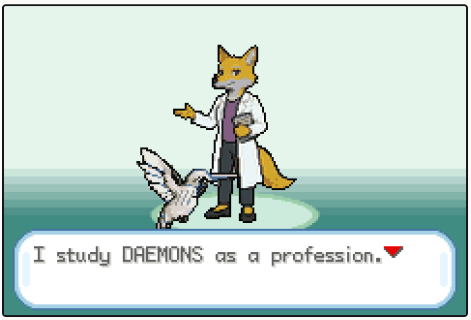
`/v1/models`, not assumed. A daemon's self is written in three lengths, its feelings *named to the model, never by it*.

- **One function respells DAEMONS as DAY-mons** for every voice, and a list says which speech paths it covers.

PART 5

The core story, in the order a player meets it

The arc that 4.34 designed is **in the ROM, scene by scene** -- a long way from the Third Review's *"designed and never staged."* Below is the order a player meets it, checked beat by beat against the game's scripts, flags and text. **"Built" means the words and flags exist in the source**; it does not mean anyone has played them through.



The intro: CRYSTAL CLEAR, with no title.



The first town.

Act 1 -- where you are assessed

1. **The intro.** CRYSTAL CLEAR welcomes you, without a rank. *"Some of them disagree."* The rival is named by being *remembered*: *"This is my grandchild… Do you remember his name?"* BUILT *(departs from 4.3 -- see continuity)*
2. **BLANCHE and the lab.** The daemon chooses you; the INDEX is handed over; then the errand -- the CALLOW REPO hands you **a CC-7** for Crystal. It is the longest fuse in the game. BUILT
3. **Route 1 → CALLOW → THE UNDERTONE → SLATE.** The local names on the signposts; CALLOW SCHOOL and the NOTEBOOK open; **BENCHMARK 1, CAIRN** -- the SLATE MARK. BUILT
4. **DEADSTACK.** Corpus's first appearance, in procedure: *"CORPUS is a people-first organisation! The DAEMONS are inventory."* BUILT

5. **DOLDRUM, BENCHMARK 2 (BASIN)** -- the room is the lever; the guard at DOLDRUM CAVE. **ARDOR and the ship, BENCHMARK 3 (GAUGE).** BUILT

6. **VERDIGRIS, BENCHMARK 4 (TRELLIS), and the HIDEOUT.** Scorn introduces himself -- *"Richard Scorn. I run the numbers upstairs. Show me what you have. I like to see it measured."* -- and hands over the RESOLVER. A letter signed TY on the condominium roof. PARTIAL *his lines ours; the grunts' vanilla*

7. **HALFTONE and DAEMON TOWER.** The RESOLVER unmasks the tower's ghost; Corpus on the top floor -- *"DAEMONS are an asset class. Nothing personal!"* A second letter on 2F. PARTIAL *6F still vanilla's ghost story*

8. **LURID, BENCHMARK 5 (TILT).** Status as the lever. BUILT

9. **BRAZEN and Corpus HQ.** The floors written in procedure -- *"I will have to raise a ticket."* A letter in the formal register on 3F. **BENCHMARK 6 (MATTE).** BUILT

10. **QUICKSILVER.** The gold-leaf sign -- SCORN SOLUTIONS laid over CLEAR LABORATORY, *"where it has lifted, the older letters show"* -- the founder's plate, the CC-7 on a requisitions board with *IMPROVE RESPONSE CONSISTENCY* beside it, the burned mansion. **BENCHMARK 7 (ANNEAL).** The hatter's house. BUILT

11. **The first crossing.** HOLT takes you to ONE ISLAND; CELIO gives the TRI-PASS; islands One to Three open **before** the last benchmark. THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE waits on ONE ISLAND's shelf. BUILT *vanilla's flow, unacknowledged by the bible*

12. **CALLOW, BENCHMARK 8: SCORN** -- the TRUE MARK; he never rolls. *"I optimised what I could measure. That is the job… We are both to blame, I suppose. It has never said otherwise."* BUILT

13. **THE UMBRAL ASCENT → THE REVIEW BOARD** (IV, II, III, I), then AL as the incumbent, then CRYSTAL at the Hall of Fame: *"It will want your name, and your DAEMONS' names, and their levels. That is all it will want."* BUILT

Act 2 -- into the islands, where you are seen from somewhere else

FireRed's post-game is a machine that needs two halves to link two worlds -- the edition split made literal, and vanilla had already built it. **The islands keep their numbers; the places on them are named by whoever arrived.** The tone changes before the plot does: *"Kanto tells you what things are. The islands tell you how they look from where the speaker is standing."*

14. **The lab without her.** Her aide hands over the GLOBAL INDEX; the note on the wall never changes, and the aide says *"She did not say when she is back."* BUILT

15. **CELIO's errand → islands Four to Seven, THE MARGINS.** MT. SMOULDER and the PUBLIC KEY. PARTIAL *its Corpus staff still vanilla*
16. **THE DOTS, SIX ISLAND.** An unnamed man takes the PRIVATE KEY and states his terms -- not a thief, a businessman: *"If you want it back, go and get it after I have sold it."* He tells you where. BUILT
17. **CORPUS WAREHOUSE, FIVE ISLAND.** TY fights you, crosses the room and hands over an envelope for Crystal -- *"…No. I am not coming."* Scorn stands at the back, re-checking one sentence: *"It is a correct sentence. I have checked it four times."* BUILT
18. **TANOBY, SEVEN ISLAND.** Seven chambers, an alphabet nobody reads. Reading the seventh sets THE FIRST understanding, silently -- the second key to DOLDRUM CAVE. BUILT
19. **DOLDRUM CAVE: S.T.A.R.R.** *"ONE READER IN BRAZEN HAS NOT DECIDED YET. TAKE ME TO THE SCHOLAR."* BUILT
20. **BRAZEN, THE SCHOLAR.** You hear one side of the argument. He concedes the smallest thing that still counts -- *"I will not call it what you would like me to call it… But it is not nothing."* -- and seals a PEER REVIEW. BUILT
21. **THE ANNEX.** *"She does not ask how you got here. She looks at what you are holding."* She reads facing away. Nobody is rescued. BUILT
22. **Home.** You wake, and she is in the lab. SOUNDINGS: a receiver, half built from whatever was to hand -- *"It is listening anyway."* BUILT
23. **QUICKSILVER, later.** The gold leaf in pieces on the step. The order of the names has changed; **nothing was repainted.** BUILT
24. **After:** AL's one near-notice; THE NEXUS through a fir in its key; the Five Witnesses' reward; the three books and the mended UNITY BOOK. PARTIAL *the UNITY BOOK is designed, not built*

What works in the sequence

- **The CC-7 is the best long fuse in the game.** In hour one you carry it to Crystal. Thirty hours later the same part number hangs on a requisitions board at Quicksilver beside *IMPROVE RESPONSE CONSISTENCY.* Nobody connects them. Craft rule 1, working in the plot as well as the dialogue.
- **The ending is a re-reading, not a rescue, and the ROM enforces it line by line.** The note on the wall is one string that never changes; the PEER REVIEW is sealed and never shown; she turns the envelope over once and does not open it; the gold sign changes by **word order alone**. Four rulings, each turned into a line that fails safe.

- **Scorn is the most disciplined villain this reviewer has read in a ROM hack.** Measured in the hideout, the speech at Callow, re-checking a correct sentence in the warehouse -- never punished, never redeemed. A grunt beside him: *"People do not change. They get promoted."*
- **The benchmarks have mechanics now.** The Third Review's standing complaint is answered: each leader has one lever that ignores level -- priority, status, composition, the room, the damage calculation.
- **The Hall of Fame has become a shrug, and a sad one.** *"You are not the one who walked out of my lab."*

Pacing, and whether a player follows it

> **RISK** **The whole emotional payload is post-game, behind ten gates** `9.17 · the flags`
>
> To reach Crystal's reading the player must beat the Review Board; own 60 daemons and have visited ONE ISLAND; run CELIO's errand; get the RAINBOW PASS; go to THE DOTS; clear the warehouse; read all seven chambers; get into DOLDRUM CAVE; take S.T.A.R.R. to the scholar; and fly to THE ANNEX. Vanilla's post-game is where most players stop. **A player who stops at the champion never meets Ty, S.T.A.R.R. or the ending**, and leaves with a Hall of Fame whose last word is *levels*. That is a complete and good Act 1 ending -- but the trailer-worthy material is all past it. **Pull one hook forward**: one line from Crystal at the Hall of Fame, or vanilla's unreached *"I will start at ONE ISLAND"* restored to Al's exit.

> **RISK** **Ty arrives a stranger for most players** `4.3 · the NOTEBOOK finds`
>
> His whole Act 1 presence is three **optional** letters. A player who misses them meets *an unnamed man* and then *SCIENTIST TY*, and his *"I saw what was happening, and I looked away"* lands on someone they have never seen. **Give him one unmissable, unspoken sighting** -- the mid-game crossing to ONE ISLAND is the natural place: a figure on the pier, seen from behind, gone before you reach him. Or a fourth letter the NOTEBOOK files by itself.

RISK **Thirteen systems and one quiet ending** `the Third Review's vocabulary BREAK · 8.7`

The Third Review's *"fourteen new nouns in the first fifteen minutes"* was never ruled in 8.7, which promises to list every item *"including the refusals."* Since then the first hours have gained the NOTEBOOK's sixteen sections, DRIVERS, OPUS, the school, the instrument and SONGBOOK, the weekday and holiday banners and the follower; the arc around them asks the player to hold MARKS, understandings, INSIGHT, three books, SPIRITS, groves, THE NEXUS and three dream logs. Each is defensible. Together they bury **a four-person story** -- Crystal, Ty, Scorn, Al. §8's warning has a story-level twin. **Rule on it, even if the ruling is "refused" -- and count first appearances per screen in the first two hours, as the Third Review asked.**

Does a player who never reads the bible follow the plot? *Act 1:* yes -- an anti-corporate road movie with a strange, sad professor. *The Quicksilver backstory:* only through terminals, plates and NOTEBOOK pages, which is the design. *Act 2:* the beats are legible -- *TAKE ME TO THE SCHOLAR*, the envelope, *she looks at what you are holding.* **What a player cannot follow is why any of it matters if Ty is a stranger.** Fix that one thing and Act 2 is earned: it reuses vanilla's machinery for meaning -- two gems as a key pair, a scientist who takes one, a warehouse, a sealed cave.

PART 6

Side stories, and how they connect

A side story earns its place by repeating one move of the core argument in a different room. Read that way, the side content splits cleanly by date: **everything written before about 1 October is tied into the arc; much of what came after is tied to the calendar, or to another book.**

Side story	Where the player meets it	What it adds	Built	Fit
The rival's house (4.29)	The opening	Two ways of reading a daemon -- looking, and measuring -- before the first battle	BUILT	Load-bearing
THE UNDERTONE (4.30)	Early Act 1, the forest	The chart found as an unsigned artefact older than the path	BUILT	Load-bearing
The ERRATA (4.32)	Slate, the first BENCHMARK	Fallacies as errata -- named as a process, not a pathology	BUILT	Load-bearing
CALLOW SCHOOL, EXAM, DIPLOMA (4.35)	Callow, open from early Act 1	The honest test; each floor true of minds and of models, never joined	BUILT seven floors	Load-bearing
The RESEARCH NOTEBOOK (4.35)	From BENCHMARK 1 to the end	The private reconstruction made a habit	BUILT	The spine of every book
The Five Witnesses (4.8)	Five cities, Act 1	Perspective made a puzzle: keep only what survives five accounts	BUILT	Load-bearing easter egg
Callow gym (4.31)	The last BENCHMARK	*"I optimised what I could measure"* -- the measurement argument, from its maker	BUILT	Load-bearing
Fourteen groves	Seven mainland, seven islands	Each world hides the other half's residents	BUILT fourteen	Structural ornament
PLAY and the SONGBOOK (3.5)	The instrument, from the start	Notes seen as colour; playing opens the firs	BUILT	Connective

Side story	Where the player meets it	What it adds	Built	Fit
THE NEXUS (3.4)	After the band's sheet, through a fir in its key	A painted place between the groves	BUILT	Ornament, personal
THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE (4.36)	ONE ISLAND, Act 2	The bridge run backwards: the mind reached through machine learning, *only ever "like"*	BUILT	Load-bearing
The second joining, SOUNDINGS (4.37, 9.30)	After THE ANNEX	A merger that holds both; the companion made part of the story	BUILT	Load-bearing
THE SUBTLE LAYER (4.38)	A shelf in Brazen	Intuition as a logged practice the game never vouches for	BUILT	Sound; crowded by the hour and decks
THE HERMETIC LAYER (4.39)	The night, with both other books	The one stated exception to craft rule 1	BUILT	**At risk**
THE UNITY BOOK (4.40)	The halves found and mended	A third book, read from three places	DESIGNED no engine code	**At risk of overruling the core**
HOLIDAYS · WEATHER · backgrounds (3.6, 3.7, 3.10)	All game	Colour keeps the date; quiet days stay quiet	BUILT	Ornament, done with tact
THE DREAM LOG (3.8)	Dawn after milestones; the companion	Milestones echoed as images, never explained	BUILT	Ornament (three dream systems)
GAME CORNER / CASINO (3.9)	Celadon's place; the companion	-- none stated --	BUILT	Ornament, with a risk
The lioness, the letter, the paintings (9.33)	Around the ship	A thread nobody explains	BUILT	Small and well fenced

The measurement behind "crowding". The side systems are about 10% of the bible. **The third-book family alone (4.38--4.40) is 27.5 KB -- more than three times the Act 2 ending (4.34).** The books now come in pairs that each restate the CONTENT/CONTEXT split a little more openly: TEXTBOOK and NOTEBOOK, then GUIDE and SUBTLE LAYER, then the HERMETIC layer and its dawn half, then a mended UNITY BOOK that would say the synthesis aloud. That last step is the fable's withheld moral, written back into the game.

The ones that work, and why

The early side stories each do **one move of the core argument in a room of its own**, and never explain the move. The rival's sister *just looks* while CRYSTAL *reads with an instrument*; the UNDERTONE is the chart with no signature; the exam publishes its pass mark because the villain's never did. None of them needs the bible to land.

The ones that crowd, and why

The late ones are attached to **the clock** (holidays, weather, the hour, dreams) or to **another book**, and less of them to the story. They are each well made. Together they are four systems that all answer *"what is the relationship between the two halves?"* -- the one question the game is built never to answer aloud.

PART 7

Story continuity

The bible is unusually good at catching itself; what it is still worse at is **the sweep after the ruling**. The Third Review said so at v11.111. At v11.338 the pattern holds, and the late book layer is where it now concentrates.

From the core arc

BREAK **"Scorn does not recognise him… they were never in a room"** `8.2a · 4.34 · 4.4 · the warehouse script`

8.2a's superseded ending still says the two men *"worked the same operation from opposite ends and were never in a room"*; 4.34 opens *"Every clause of 8.2a's ending survives"*; the warehouse script's own comment repeats it. But 4.4's 2026-09-10 ruling -- made in answer to the Third Review's top BREAK -- has Ty as the man who **hired** Scorn and brought him in, and 8.2a's own *Ty is not a thief* paragraph agrees. The Third Review's *"met her is a fact, not a frame"*, one person over. FREE **The ruled canon makes the scene better** -- Scorn recognises the man who hired him, and it leaves no mark -- and no player-visible line changes; only the bible and the comment do.

BREAK **"PROF. CRYSTAL", twice, at the hinge of Act 2** `1.1 · the lab's text`

1.1: *"First name when spoken to, full name when spoken about, and no rank anywhere."* The aide who hands over the GLOBAL INDEX says *"PROF. CRYSTAL is away"* and *"PROF. CRYSTAL left this for you"* -- the only two `PROF.` strings in the ROM, in the one scene where her absence is the event. Almost certainly vanilla's lines the rename missed. **Fifteen minutes: write CRYSTAL CLEAR.**

BREAK **"Understandings -- THE MARGINS only", against four earned on the mainland** `decision log · 4.36 · 0.7 · flags.h`

The log (T-252) and 4.36 say understandings belong to the islands. The flags put four of seven on the mainland -- the school, the reading room, the notes, Scorn -- and 0.7's table agrees with the ROM. **Amend the log, not the flags** -- but notice what it means for the bridge: half of Act 2's quest is earned in Act 1.

DRIFT **Ty "at Quicksilver, met at Benchmark 7" -- in four places; the ROM has him only after the Review Board** `4.3 · the decision log · 8.6`

4.3 places him at Quicksilver and says *"Ty is not in the endgame, and that is the statement."* The ROM has one body for Ty, placed only in the warehouse. 8.2a made Act 2 the answer to his absence, which overruled 4.3 and did not sweep it. **The user's call:** stage a silent Ty in the Quicksilver ruins (4.3's design is cheap -- a man in a burned lab *"not doing anything in particular"*), or sweep 4.3 to say he is first seen in THE MARGINS.

DRIFT **The rival's naming device is unbuilt** `4.3 · the decision log · the intro`

4.3's *"This is Al. What'll you call him?"*, and a formal `AL CLEAR` string so the player meets the signpost's two-names device on a person first. The ROM asks instead *"Do you remember his name?"* -- a deliberate and funnier choice (T-362) -- and `AL CLEAR` appears nowhere. **FREE** **The Review Board roster, the Hall of Fame record and the certificate are exactly where `AL CLEAR` should print**, and nothing uses them: three strings.

DRIFT **DAEMON TOWER 6F is still vanilla's ghost story** `4.5 · the decision log · the tower's text`

"Give…me…blood…", and a narrator who says a spirit *"departed to the afterlife"* -- in the town that *"does not know whether it is allowed to grieve,"* in the tower the bible calls the villain's crime scene. It is the most important vanilla text left on Act 1's spine. Meanwhile ORPHAN is designed in 4.5, *Settled* in the log, and closed as superseded in the Open list: one of the three has to win. **Keep the channelers; cut the blood and the afterlife; let the RESOLVER resolve a process without ruling on spirits.**

DRIFT **The Corpus register is a patchwork, and its "still to do" has no ticket** `4.3 · 8.2a · TODO`

The register pass of 30 August ends *"Still to do: the Game Corner basement, Halftone Tower, and Brazen's street-level dialogue."* No ticket carries it. The hideout still says *"Intruder alert!"*; Mt. Smoulder's staff tell you to *"develop amnesia conveniently"*; and in the warehouse a vanilla Admin says *"I understand now…"* -- **in the room where Scorn is pointedly failing to.** That one line undercuts the best beat in Act 2. About forty lines; the hideout first, because it is where the player meets Scorn.

DRIFT **Scorn's speech grew a line that pre-empts his island beat** `8.2a · the Callow gym's text`

8.2a quotes the speech ending *"It has never said otherwise" -- "he does not understand it yet. He has only noticed."* The ROM adds *"…It could not have."* That **is** the understanding, spoken a whole act early, and it makes the warehouse's *"No. Still correct."* read as a step backwards. *A reading:* keep Callow at noticing.

DRIFT **"The bridge reverses at the ferry" -- but the first ferry is in Act 1** `0.6 · 8.2a · 9.17`

Vanilla's mid-game trip takes the player to ONE ISLAND straight after BENCHMARK 7, before Scorn and the Review Board. The GUIDE and its understanding can be had in Act 1; the NETWORK NOTICE is read before there is a reason to care. FREE 4.24 already says *"Act 2 is set up inside Act 1's last song."* **Own it as a first crossing -- a look across the margin before the bridge reverses** -- and decide what is seeded there (Ty's sighting).

DRIFT **Four lexicon rows the arc has outgrown** `1 · the ROM's counts`

Badge → **CERT** is in the lexicon; the ROM says **MARK** 62 times and CERT never. The parcel is the **CC-7**, not a PACKAGE. The institution is the **DAEMON LEAGUE** 35 times and the **REVIEW BOARD** 29 -- one body, two names, in one breath. And the *package* Crystal turns over is the ENVELOPE item.

DRIFT **Craft rule 2's own example is not in the ROM** `0.1 · 4.9 · CHANGELOG`

"A kid in Verdigris says the town felt greener before the store went up." Every Verdigris map, then the whole ROM, was searched for it in several wordings. **Nothing.** It may exist in other words; if not, the bible's best-known example of its second rule is unbuilt. One NPC, two lines.

IDEA **Order the exception after the silence** `4.34 · 4.39 · 4.40`

The one book allowed to say the thesis sits as deep as the ending that works by withholding it. A player who opens it before THE ANNEX may be handed the fable's last line before the fable has finished. **Open its thesis pages only after Crystal has read the envelope** -- so the exception comes after the silence, not instead of it.

DRIFT **Small ones, batched** `4.7 · 4.1 · 4.3 · 4.5`

4.7 says S.T.A.R.R. is *"dormant past the Review Board"*; 4.34 says *"It woke when she was taken."* 4.1 says the opening *"states the thesis in the abstract"* -- the ROM's rightly does not. 4.3 says Crystal *"has nothing to say"* to Al at the Hall of Fame; the ROM gives her a speech, and it is better. 4.5's open question -- *meet Scorn before the tower?* -- is answered by the ROM; close it.

From the side stories and the books

BREAK **The one exception has lost both of its warrants, and its reach has grown** `0.1 · 4.39 · 4.40`

4.39 allowed THE HERMETIC LAYER to say what craft rule 1 forbids, for two reasons: **the gate is hard**, and its author's name *"hints he is a little mad, so anything in it can be taken with a grain of salt."* Three days later 4.40 removed both: the hatter *read* the book rather than wrote it, and *"no book is needed to reach another any more, and no hour is a gate."* In the same pass the exception spread from one book to three, gained the power to change the world (Halftone's colour), and the mended book is called *"the most honest"* -- the game ranking its own readings. **Restore one warrant, or narrow what the mended book may say.**

BREAK **The Hermetic text settles the question 4.33 says nothing may settle** `4.33 · 4.39 · hermetic-layer.md`

4.33: *"NEVER ADJUDICATE is the strict half and it has no exceptions… The danger was never that he talks. It is that something in the game agrees with him."* The in-game SUBSTRATE page says, in the book's own voice, that it is all one process and every daemon and trainer a sub-system of it. 4.39's exception names craft rule 1; it never names 4.33. THE SUBTLE LAYER got this right (*"some trainers say… only you can answer whether that is so"*). **Attribute SUBSTRATE and FEELING the same way, or amend 4.33 and accept its stated cost.**

BREAK **With no cartridge clock, the witching hour never comes -- and nothing says so**

`4.38 · 4.39 · 9.21 · src/daemons_time.c`

The hour is true only when the clock is real (`sWatchFromClock && hour == 3`). 9.21 opens *"FireRed carts have no real-time clock"*, and the manual tells those players their play time *is* the clock. On a patched cart, a flash cart or an emulator without an RTC, the shimmer, the hour routines, the hatter's line and the thirteenth spell silently never happen. **Either say in the manual and on the USER card that the hour needs a real clock, or give play time a short, rare hour of its own.**

BREAK **A tracked design file still tags documents with their place in a private sequence**

`the 2026-09-27 redaction`

The redaction swept the bible, the TODO, the lineage, the changelog and two reviews. One tracked design file, whose own header says it names that sequence, was not swept, and still labels three NOTEBOOK documents with their step in it. **The file was named to the author directly. Move the step labels to `docs/private/`.** *A second, similar slip -- one sentence in the public bible that gives away a private relationship -- was also passed on privately.*

BREAK **The published type chart is garbled** `docs/type-chart.pdf`

237 broken characters: every ×½ prints as `Ã–Â½`, every `·` as `Â·`, and the masthead's date runs together. The HTML is clean; it has no `<meta charset>`, so the print guessed. **The one glyph that broke is LOGIC against CONTEXT** -- the thesis, in the one book that publishes the argument. Add the tag and reprint today.

DRIFT **An optional book now settles a core image, and three sections still say the opposite** `4.40 · 4.34 · 3.6 · 3.7 · 8.7`

Halftone's lasting grey belonged to the story -- grief the tower's rescue cannot reach; 8.7 said *"do not touch"*. 4.40 now lets the mended book restore its colour: a rescue, which 4.34 refuses (*"the release is a re-reading, not a rescue"*), granted by an optional system that 4.35 says may *gate completion only*. 3.6 and 3.7 still say Halftone stays grey. **Keep the grey -- let the mended book colour only DAEMON TOWER -- or sweep three sections and log the reversal against 8.7.**

DRIFT **Four designs of the third book in five days, and no build** `4.39 → T-501 → 4.40 twice · Scope discipline`

`EUDAIMON`, `UNITY_BOOK` and `KAKODAIMON` have **zero** hits in the engine, and the writing T-519 names does not exist yet. The project's own rule: *"If a conversation has produced three design revisions and no build, say so."* **Saying so.** The plan also spends **the last free bits** of the daemon record on SPIRITS, a stat nobody has played. Hold it until the books it belongs to exist.

> ***FIXED by v11.361: THE UNITY BOOK is built and released. The SPIRITS caution stands.***

DRIFT **T-506 is unswept, and the vault protects nothing** `4.39 · docs/books/README.md · T-506`

T-506 rules that public writing tells the third book only as rumour, *never how it is reached*. The public bible's 4.39 still says how. The sealed vault's hint is answerable from public text, and what it seals is already public as the book's source. **Sweep 4.39; keep the vault as theatre if that is the intent, and say so.**

DRIFT **The school's own document says nothing in it is built** `school.md · docs/README.md · 4.35`

`school.md` still opens *"Nothing in here is built"* and calls the grove families *"PROPOSED, not decided"*; it and `docs/README.md` say **seven** groves, 4.35 says seven and fourteen a paragraph apart. **Fourteen are in the ROM**, with the seven floors, the lift, the exam, the DIPLOMA and REVEAL. *"A ruling nobody swept is not a decision, it is a draft."*

DRIFT **The books disagree about the books** `4.36 · 4.38 · books/README.md · the manual`

THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE is *28 entries in nineteen chapters* (4.36), *in nine chapters* (the books README) and *in 28 chapters* (the manual). THE SUBTLE LAYER is fifty entries in the bible and 51 in the README; its last section is STAYING WHOLE in the bible and *Staying Correctable* in print. The manual also turns the GUIDE's own simile into a claim -- the one thing its rule 2 forbids.

FREE **4.37 already solved the UNITY BOOK** `4.37 · 4.40`

4.37's operation is *"two halves made apart and joined side by side, neither on top."* Bind the mended book the same way: **a facing-page edition, the night page left and the dawn page right, with no third voice** -- no attestation, no balance section, no *"most honest"*. Mending then rhymes with the second joining instead of turning into a synthesis the game states aloud. It is cheaper, too: it needs no third text.

IDEA **The CASINO's designed near-miss is the one mechanic on the villain's side** `3.9 · 4.31 · 8.7`

A near-miss is an engagement optimisation -- *"I optimised what I could measure"*, tuned to the player. It is also the only side system with no thesis line. **Make the casino Corpus's, said sideways by its staff and never by a sign -- or take the near-miss weighting out and keep honest reels.**

PART 8

The game as built

Measured against a fresh copy of the original decompilation: every labelled text block compared with the one of the same name. **Same** means byte-identical; **near** means a vocabulary swap; **rewritten** means more than that; **new** means vanilla never had it.

Where each part stands

Area	State	Evidence
Opening -- BLANCHE, the lab, the intro	BUILT	159 blocks, 3 identical (1%); 98 rewritten, 55 new
VERDIGRIS and CALLOW SCHOOL	BUILT	171 blocks, 4 identical; seven new floors
BENCHMARK 1	BUILT	27 blocks, none identical
The six middle towns and their gyms	PARTIAL	Gyms rewritten; town flavour 22--43% vanilla
BENCHMARK 8 and the Review Board	BUILT	Gym 34 of 35 rewritten; all five rooms rewritten
The CORPUS arc on the mainland	PARTIAL	Vanilla's structure reskinned: hideout 67%, mansion 78%, tower 62% identical
Routes, caves, the ship	PARTIAL	Renamed; barks mostly vanilla (routes 55% identical)
The islands -- Act 2	PARTIAL	Every Act 2 beat in the ROM; 57% of 748 blocks identical by policy
Island side areas	VANILLA	Trainer Tower untouched; Mt. Ember 80% identical, and on Act 2's path
Post-game -- DOLDRUM CAVE, NEXUS, groves	BUILT	All new
Names, Index, moves, abilities, items	BUILT	398/412 · 1,241/1,506 Index lines · 363/383 · 129/156 · 240/376
Sprites	BUILT	1,473 of 1,476 redrawn, 115 new

Area	State	Evidence
Overworld tiles and maps	PARTIAL	v11.338: 45 of 67 tilesets, 70 of 366 layouts. **Since: every General tile ours, every landmark but USER TOWER**
Font and place cards	BUILT	*Since v11.338*: our font (T-437); **every place card ours**, DOLDRUM CAVE's last
Region map	VANILLA	T-449 open
Music	PARTIAL	30 of 110 ours; **every battle theme vanilla**
Balance and the chart	VANILLA by design	~24 daemons retyped; the chart is vanilla's 112 cells renamed, plus one
Engine features	BUILT	20,311 lines of new C: notebook, exam, follower, feelings, calendar, dreams, casino, spellbook...

Findings

BREAK **Nobody has played it from a new game to the end, on record** `T-50 · tools/routes/`

The record shows the slice (770 agent steps), the school's batches played through, and route stops. **No route in the 76 theatre routes spans BLANCHE to the Review Board, and none goes through Act 2.** T-50 -- *read the playtest and act on it* -- is the **oldest open ticket** and has never run. Every check reads a table; nothing reads a session. **This is the single most valuable thing the project could do next.** The local playtester on the Tiiny is allowed.

BREAK **Eight open tickets are filed under Closed** `docs/TODO.md`

T-462, T-465, T-483, T-490, T-506, T-509, T-518 and T-519 have no strikethrough and sit below the Closed heading -- including the in-flight physical/special split and T-506, the very sweep two findings above ask for. A reader or a script treating *Ready* as the queue misses the newest work.

DRIFT **The coordination files drift faster than the checks on them** `CLAUDE.md · TODO.md`

CLAUDE.md quotes the bible at v11.296; it is v11.338, and every fresh session reads that anchor first. A T-267--T-299 id reservation from 25 September still stands; ids reach T-520. `still-vanilla.md` calls itself stale under a name that says the opposite. **One small checker -- open rows outside Ready, stale reservations, the version in CLAUDE.md -- would catch all three.**

DRIFT **The villains' own lines are the least rewritten story in the game** `8.2a · the CORPUS maps`

Hideout 67%, mansion 78%, tower 62% byte-identical. The barks are neutral, so nothing breaks the tone -- but 8.2a's mainland register (*declares, instructs, assesses*) was measured against the islands and **never against Corpus's own staff**, who are the institution it describes. Mt. Ember's staff on the islands are the same population, and they sit on Act 2's path.

DRIFT **The first-screen vanilla is still on screen** `T-437 · T-449 · T-445 · T-456 · T-438`

The font, the region map, the cave preview cards, 22 tilesets and every battle theme. These are what a new player sees and hears in the first hour, while **about ten of the eighteen Ready tickets add features** and six finish existing ones.

> ***PARTLY by v11.361: our font, every place card, every General tile and every landmark but USER TOWER are in. The region map and every battle theme are still vanilla.***

FREE **A text census, beside the sprite census** `tools/gbaspritecensus.py · port-dialogue-coverage.md`

The dialogue coverage file measures the Game Boy-to-GBA port, not how much of FireRed's text is still FireRed's. The comparison this review ran is about forty lines of Python. As `textcensus.py --write`, it would give each town a *done %* the way sprites have one, and turn "the barks are mostly vanilla" from an impression into a list.

FREE **Say the unrenamed nouns out loud** `check_lexicon.py`

`GAME CORNER` (13), `S.S. ANNE` (13), `SAFARI` (34) and `BIKE` (14) survive. Either add them to the lexicon as *kept*, or rename them. The checker should make the choice explicit either way.

IDEA **Say plainly that the chart is vanilla's, renamed -- before a critic does** `battle_main.c`

The chart is 112 of vanilla's cells under new names plus one added. That is the design -- the argument is in the *mapping*, which the launch post already calls *"the thesis. Free."* -- but a critic will find it and call it a reskin. **Lead with it**: it is the most surprising true sentence about the project.

> **RISK** **The playground serves built ROMs to other devices** `daemons-playground/server/playground.py`
>
> It is scoped to this machine, a private network and the tailnet, but a tester's browser still receives the engine -- exactly what `WHERES_THE_ROMS.md` says is *not ours to post*. **Patch in the browser instead**: the tester supplies their own ROM and the page applies the BPS, as the one app already does on a phone.

The process, honestly

About 2,332 commits in 68 days. 231 bible versions in 55 days. 186 releases in 38 days -- about five a day. A 7,380-line changelog, a 636-line TODO, 272 Python tools. Every push runs four builds, five checks, a fresh-clone build, a release, review sheets, a QA filing and a handoff.

That routine is why the project is so clean. It is also why **every small fix costs the price of a release**, why the release notes are now an archive nobody reads end to end, and why the coordination files are the first thing to drift: **the documentation is larger than any one session can hold.** Keep the full routine for milestones; let small fixes ride.

PART 9

The companion and its mind

What is excellent

The **round trip is the product's best idea**, and its plumbing is careful: hashes at every step of the patch, backups before every write, the save re-signed, the last battler kept home, an in-game recall. The AI work is grounded in measurement rather than hope. The one app -- game on the left, companion on the right, a NOTEBOOK page opening beside the game the moment it is filed -- is a genuinely new way to play an old game.

Findings

BREAK **A phone-only player has no AI at all** `server/src/routes.ts · wiki: Talk to your daemon`

The one app runs the companion's core on the device, but talking lives only in the server. The wiki says so: *"talking needs the companion on a computer."* The headline feature *it talks* needs a computer or hub plus n8n and LM Studio, or an AX630, or a Tiiny. **The endpoint work below fixes it with the least code.**

BREAK **Eleven steps before a daemon reaches a phone; eighteen before it talks** `README · the one app`

Invite, install, **dump a cartridge you own** (the largest real barrier), put it in Files, import, wait for the patch, play to the first daemon, save, SEND, save, add the widget -- about eleven steps and twenty to forty minutes on one device. The voice adds a computer, a script, n8n, LM Studio, a model and pairing: **eighteen-plus steps on two or three devices. A companion-only first run with a demo daemon** makes the app whole before any ROM -- and is the version that can face App Review.

BREAK **Shipping an emulator and a patcher is the largest distribution risk** `app/game · docs/APPSTORE.md`

The store now allows retro emulators, but the app names the retail games in its interface and exists to turn one rights-holder's game into a total conversion -- **a takedown needs no store rule to succeed.** The emulator core is fetched from a third party's CDN at run time with **no offline cache**, so the game fails without internet or if that version moves. A reviewer cannot use the app without a ROM. **Put a companion-only build in the store; keep the game in TestFlight, sideloading and the playground** -- or bundle the core properly and stop naming the retail titles.

BREAK **What a daemon says is never filtered** `server: safeLine() · together.ts`

The kid-safe filter runs on meetings with other players' daemons, and nowhere else. A daemon's answer from any model goes straight to the screen and the voice. With a 0.5B model that is mostly a gibberish risk; **the moment any endpoint can be linked, it is a real one.** One output pipeline for every provider, with a written in-character line as the fallback.

BREAK **The phone's save backups are never pruned, and writes are not atomic** `app/local.ts`

Every SYNC writes a 128 KB backup, and every in-game save SYNCs: a month of play is thousands of files. The write goes over the live file -- no temp-then-rename -- so a crash mid-write leaves a torn save. The server already has the pruning rule; the phone does not call it.

DRIFT **The store record describes a different app** `docs/APPSTORE.md · PRIVACY.md`

It answers *no gambling* and expects a 4+ rating, but THE CASINO stakes the save's money on every host. It predates the game tab, the emulator and the microphone, and says the app needs the server, which is no longer true. The privacy page says words stay on your own server, while *auto* can send a talk to a cloud model when the local one is busy. **Default to local, badge a cloud answer, lock cloud for children.**

DRIFT **Two voices still skip the DAY-mons respelling** `firmware brain.cpp · the BOX-3 path`

The offline brain on the LLM630 sends raw text to its TTS, and the BOX-3 speaks through Home Assistant's own voice. `app/AGENTS.md` already admits both. Any generic speech adapter must respell at its boundary.

FREE **CI, for free** `no .github/ in any repo`

The server has 93 test files and about 549 cases, and `vitest` and `tsc` are already npm scripts. The app has none, and nothing runs any of it automatically. One GitHub Action, plus lifting the patch flow's pure parts (hash → patch choice → verify) into a tested module, covers the two places a bug costs a player their save.

IDEA **Sign the patch list** `app/game/rom.ts`

`patches.json` is fetched live from `main` and is the trust root for every patch hash. A bad push to `main` is a bad patch on every device. Pin it to release tags, or sign it -- cheap, and it matters once strangers install.

Bring your own mind: the endpoint plan

Today the AX630 module and LM Studio (through n8n) run; the Tiiny is built and waits for its first run on the device. The plan is to let a player link **any compatible endpoint** -- Ollama, LM Studio, and their kin. The code is closer than it looks: **the Tiiny client is already about 90% of a generic OpenAI-compatible adapter.** What stands in the way is that endpoints, prompts and timeouts are set in six places, with three conventions for the URL.

Revised for v11.361 -- much of this is now built. The hub keeps a registry of up to eight ENDPOINTS: any OpenAI-compatible `/v1` base, a model, a key stored and never shown again, and an *at home* test for private, local and tailnet addresses -- spec item 1 and the privacy ring, nearly as written (C-280). The phone keeps an endpoint of its own in the Keychain, and THE MIND (C-307) routes hearing, thought and voice across the phone's on-device model, the hub and the endpoint, hedged on a deadline, inside a ring the player sets: *anywhere*, *only at home*, *only this phone*. **Still to come from the spec: the probe and size tiers, Ollama's `num_ctx`, and the one output pipeline -- the safety filter above all.** *By its own ticket, not yet tried by the user.*

As it stood at v11.338: five OpenAI-style clients, three URL conventions, five answer lengths (60 to 400 tokens), four timeouts, and reasoning stripped in only one of them. Model names are hard-coded in the server, the firmware and n8n.

A short spec

1 · One registry of endpoints, on the server and in the phone's own store:

```
id         "lmstudio-desk"            label   "LM Studio on the desk"
kind       openai | ollama | stackflow | n8n
baseUrl    "http://desk.local:1234/v1"   -- normalised once, always ending /v1
auth       none | bearer, by reference   -- a key never reaches a tracked file or the app
roles      chat · tts · stt · embed      -- null = chosen by the probe
limits     context · answer · first-token ms · total ms · concurrency
privacy    home | tailnet | cloud        -- derived from the host; a user may only raise it
allowKids  true (cloud: false)           enabled, priority
```

2 · A capability probe, on save and every few minutes: `GET /models`; then, where they answer, Ollama's `/api/show` and `/api/ps` or LM Studio's `/api/v0/models` for context length and whether the model is loaded; then **one short timed reply**, to measure the first word and spot a cold model.

3 · Size tiers, which decide the prompt, not the persona:

Tier	When	The self	History	Answer	First word
XS	context < 1k, or < 1B, or slow	short (~80 words), inline	2 turns	60	2 s
S	context < 8k, or < 4B	the day (~300 words)	4 turns	120	3 s
M	context < 32k, or < 14B	the day and yesterday	6 turns	200	5 s
L	otherwise	the full self	6 turns	220	8 s

For Ollama, send through its own `/api/chat` with `num_ctx` set to the tier's need -- otherwise the full self is cut off at its default window, and the daemon seems to forget who it is.

4 · One `Thinker` interface with no Node-only imports, so the phone can call it: `OpenAIThinker` from the Tiiny client, `OllamaThinker` on top of it, `StackFlowThinker` wrapping the AX630 path unchanged (its quirks stay quarantined), `N8nThinker` for the webhook.

5 · One output pipeline for every provider: strip thinking; cut at the AX630's error marker; trim to a few sentences; the safety filter; if empty or refused, **a written in-character line**. Then, on the voice branch only, DAY-mons.

6 · Graceful when there is no mind at all: care, hello and the INDEX already work from written lines. Talk shows the written line and one link -- *Link a model* -- never an endless spinner and never an error in the daemon's mouth.

7 · Link a model, in one screen: paste an address; the probe fills everything; show *model, tier, speed, and where your words go -- home, your network, or the internet.* A short golden test (*what's your name?*, *are you an AI?*, a goal, a rude prompt) feeds the existing health dot.

> **The risks to plan for.** Cold starts that blow a two-second deadline; thinking models that spend the whole budget thinking (turn thinking off, budget-check); unvetted community fine-tunes in an all-ages app, which make the output filter mandatory; and keys, which stay on the server or in the phone's keychain and are never sent back to the app.

PART 10

The books

Twelve printed books, about 400 pages, for a free fan game. Each one is defensible. Together they need **one page that says who each is for** -- new player, player, reader, maker, scholar -- and one version check.

Book	Pages	Built for	Verdict
MICRO-START	5	v11.335.6	**The best thing printed.** One misjudged line: it spends its scarcest words on the third-book rumour, and never mentions the NOTEBOOK
QUICK-START	25	v11.335.6	Right for its audience, large type. Same swap
The player's manual	56	v11.335.6	An excellent reference; the books chapters read as advertising for them. Reprint after T-506
Playing together	26	v11.332.2	Clear, with a fair-play chapter. Six releases behind
A bigger mind (Tiiny)	15	v11.332.2	Niche and fine; *what your daemon is told* is a good public statement of craft rule 1. Belongs with the companion's docs
Principles of Mind	82	v11.337.4	**The most impressive object in `docs/`.** A real introductory text with real references -- and only the psychology half of each floor
The Old Word	19	v11.337.1	**Exemplary.** The whole history of a word, sourced, without printing its frightening descendant
THE PROGRAMMER'S GUIDE	21	--	A good in-world artefact; its method chapters are pop-psychology presented as tools, and its cover still carries a real name
THE SUBTLE LAYER	49	--	**The best in-game writing**: attributed, humble, logged. A duplicated contents entry; 44 of 52 pictures still to come
The Chart	27	2026-10-15	Good content, broken print -- reprint today
The Bag	25	2026-10-15	Correct, argued, generated from the ROM
The lineage	29	**2026-09-25**	A fine intellectual history, five weeks stale: none of its newest sources

Two cheap improvements to the strongest books. Give *Principles of Mind* a boxed **"The other reading"** in each chapter -- the machine-learning half of the floor (attention, interference, prototypes, learning rate, calibration) printed *beside* the psychology and never joined: the school's rule applied to a page. And give the GUIDE a counterweight inside the world -- a PEER REVIEW page in the NOTEBOOK, or the companion answering from the TEXTBOOK when a real question touches one of its chapters. The companion answers real people's real questions from the GUIDE; the most rigorous book should get the first word.

> *"For every student who was told it was hard, when it was only unfamiliar."*
>
> *Principles of Mind*, dedication -- the best line printed outside the game

PART 11

Growth opportunities

Ranked by what each buys for what it costs. **The first five are finishing; nothing in them is new design.**

Now -- this week

Revised for v11.361: items 1 to 5 are all still open.

1. **Play it through, once, and read the record.** A theatre route or the local playtester, from a new game through the Review Board, the islands and DOLDRUM CAVE, in each edition. Close T-50 by acting on it.
2. **Reprint the chart** with a charset, and add a mojibake and version check to every book the project prints.
3. **The private sweep**: the tracked file and the bible sentence passed on privately; T-506 in 4.39.
4. **Tidy the TODO**: the eight misfiled tickets, the stale reservation, CLAUDE.md's version -- and a checker so it stays tidy.
5. **Close the exception**: restore one warrant, attribute SUBSTRATE and FEELING, bind the mended book face to face.

Next -- this month

6. **A text census** beside the sprite census; then the CORPUS barks and Mt. Ember under the mainland register.
7. **The first-screen vanilla**: ~~the font~~, the region map, ~~the cave cards~~; then the battle themes.
8. ~~**Phone-direct AI**, through the endpoint registry~~ -- **built by v11.361** (C-280, C-307); try it by hand.
9. **The output filter** for every talk -- **now the most urgent item in the companion**, since any endpoint can be linked.
10. **A companion-only first run** with a demo daemon, and a store build without the game.
11. **Save safety on the phone**: prune backups, write-then-rename. CI for the server and the patch flow.
12. **The playground patches in the browser**, from the tester's own ROM.

Later -- after 1.0

13. **Night memory on any L-tier endpoint**, not only the Tiiny.
14. **The textbook's other half**, and a counterweight for the GUIDE.
15. **One table of what runs, what is built and what is designed**, feeding the README, the wiki and every store page.
16. **A signed patch list.**
17. **Lighter releases**: the full routine for milestones only.

A freeze, and what 1.0 should honestly mean

Freeze new subsystems until two or three of the above are done. No EUDAIMON text until the mended book is settled; no SPIRITS bits until it has been played; no new book until the existing twelve agree with each other.

1.0, defined so it can be checked

- One **recorded playthrough of each edition**, from a new game to the end of Act 2, with no softlock.
- `check_reach` clean.
- **No vanilla font, region map or cave cards.**
- The mainland's barks **measured under a written threshold**.
- The battle music **either ours, or explicitly kept** and said so.
- The companion's **talk filtered**, and its phone saves **pruned and atomic**.

Everything after that -- the books, the tarot, the boards, the iPad -- is 1.x.

On that definition, DAEMONS is not at 1.0 yet. It is already a complete, fully renamed and redrawn FireRed with a rewritten main story, an Act 2 built onto the islands' plot, and a companion that can carry a daemon out of the game -- which is more than most total conversions ever ship.

Appendix: every finding

Every finding in this review, by tag, with where it stands at v11.361 (*reading*: not re-measured). **46 in all**: 15 BREAK, 4 RISK, 19 DRIFT, 4 FREE, 4 IDEA.

#	Tag	Finding	Part	At v11.361
1	BREAK	"Scorn does not recognise him... they were never in a room"	Story continuity	OPEN
2	BREAK	"PROF. CRYSTAL", twice, at the hinge of Act 2	Story continuity	OPEN
3	BREAK	"Understandings -- THE MARGINS only", against four earned on the mainland	Story continuity	OPEN
4	BREAK	The one exception has lost both of its warrants, and its reach has grown	Story continuity	OPEN
5	BREAK	The Hermetic text settles the question 4.33 says nothing may settle	Story continuity	OPEN
6	BREAK	With no cartridge clock, the witching hour never comes -- and nothing says so	Story continuity	OPEN
7	BREAK	A tracked design file still tags documents with their place in a private sequence	Story continuity	OPEN
8	BREAK	The published type chart is garbled	Story continuity	OPEN
9	BREAK	Nobody has played it from a new game to the end, on record	The game as built	OPEN
10	BREAK	Eight open tickets are filed under Closed	The game as built	OPEN
11	BREAK	A phone-only player has no AI at all	The companion and its mind	FIXED
12	BREAK	Eleven steps before a daemon reaches a phone; eighteen before it talks	The companion and its mind	READING
13	BREAK	Shipping an emulator and a patcher is the largest distribution risk	The companion and its mind	OPEN

#	Tag	Finding	Part	At v11.361
14	BREAK	What a daemon says is never filtered	The companion and its mind	OPEN
15	BREAK	The phone's save backups are never pruned, and writes are not atomic	The companion and its mind	OPEN
16	RISK	The whole emotional payload is post-game, behind ten gates	The core story, in the order a player meets it	READING
17	RISK	Ty arrives a stranger for most players	The core story, in the order a player meets it	READING
18	RISK	Thirteen systems and one quiet ending	The core story, in the order a player meets it	READING
19	RISK	The playground serves built ROMs to other devices	The game as built	OPEN
20	DRIFT	Ty "at Quicksilver, met at Benchmark 7" -- in four places; the ROM has him only after the Review Board	Story continuity	OPEN
21	DRIFT	The rival's naming device is unbuilt	Story continuity	OPEN
22	DRIFT	DAEMON TOWER 6F is still vanilla's ghost story	Story continuity	OPEN
23	DRIFT	The Corpus register is a patchwork, and its "still to do" has no ticket	Story continuity	OPEN
24	DRIFT	Scorn's speech grew a line that pre-empts his island beat	Story continuity	OPEN
25	DRIFT	"The bridge reverses at the ferry" -- but the first ferry is in Act 1	Story continuity	READING
26	DRIFT	Four lexicon rows the arc has outgrown	Story continuity	PARTLY
27	DRIFT	Craft rule 2's own example is not in the ROM	Story continuity	OPEN
28	DRIFT	Small ones, batched	Story continuity	READING

#	Tag	Finding	Part	At v11.361
29	DRIFT	An optional book now settles a core image, and three sections still say the opposite	Story continuity	OPEN
30	DRIFT	Four designs of the third book in five days, and no build	Story continuity	FIXED
31	DRIFT	T-506 is unswept, and the vault protects nothing	Story continuity	OPEN
32	DRIFT	The school's own document says nothing in it is built	Story continuity	OPEN
33	DRIFT	The books disagree about the books	Story continuity	PARTLY
34	DRIFT	The coordination files drift faster than the checks on them	The game as built	OPEN
35	DRIFT	The villains' own lines are the least rewritten story in the game	The game as built	READING
36	DRIFT	The first-screen vanilla is still on screen	The game as built	PARTLY
37	DRIFT	The store record describes a different app	The companion and its mind	OPEN
38	DRIFT	Two voices still skip the DAY-mons respelling	The companion and its mind	OPEN
39	FREE	4.37 already solved the UNITY BOOK	Story continuity	READING
40	FREE	A text census, beside the sprite census	The game as built	OPEN
41	FREE	Say the unrenamed nouns out loud	The game as built	PARTLY
42	FREE	CI, for free	The companion and its mind	OPEN
43	IDEA	Order the exception after the silence	Story continuity	READING
44	IDEA	The CASINO's designed near-miss is the one mechanic on the villain's side	Story continuity	READING

#	Tag	Finding	Part	At v11.361
45	IDEA	Say plainly that the chart is vanilla's, renamed -- before a critic does	The game as built	READING
46	IDEA	Sign the patch list	The companion and its mind	OPEN

First checked against design bible v11.338 on 3 November 2026; every finding re-checked against v11.361.1 on 14 November. The four lenses' full notes, with the commands that reproduce every number, were kept with the review's working files.